



Water Dragon Foundation Project Completion Report AI Mentor for Young People

AI became a first source of support for teenagers, across family backgrounds

AI Mentor helps young people discuss concerns by chat and choose a first step for today. The project focuses on young people from single-parent households. From 1 to 10 August 2026, 507 people aged 15–19 used AI Mentor, including 73 from mother-led households (14.4%). We assessed outcomes through questions before and after consultation.

507 users followed one consultation flow

This page explains the consultation flow, three outcomes and three comparison groups. All figures in the report use these definitions.

Consultation flow for all 507 users

- 1

Before consultation
Age, family circumstances, daily life, aspirations, concerns and current problems
- 2

Consultation with AI Mentor
Discuss concerns by chat and choose a first step for today (pp. 7–8)
- 3

Immediately after consultation
What users learned, today's action, remaining problems and how they decided
- 4

Reading two stories
1. A project story about global income differences and IIT scholarships.
2. A message from an IIT Hyderabad (IITH) student. Users then described their reactions.

507 users aged 15–19 across all 47 prefectures
360 high-school students (71.0%), 372 female (73.4%)

Terms used in this report

Three outcomes of consultation

- Chose a first step**

Chose a type of action to take today. Excludes undecided, unsure and prefer-not-to-answer responses. Subsequent action was not measured.
- Clarification / decision**

Selected at least one item: a clearer goal, options or information, clarified concerns, or deciding what to do today.
- Selected / adapted**

Selected among AI suggestions, adapted a suggestion to their circumstances, or devised a different action themselves.

Three ways to compare users

- Mother-led / two-parent households**

73 named their mother as the main parent or guardian. The comparison group includes 316 reporting both parents, after excluding overlapping categories.
- Lower-resource / other households**

Excluding unsure / declined responses, 158 of 463 reported 0–3 resources and 305 reported 4–9. Items include meals out, travel, a car, tutoring, materials, activities, a desk and discussing education costs without worry. This is not an income measure.
- Concrete / non-concrete descriptions**

Could describe what they discussed with AI in the post-consultation response, versus brief replies such as 'unsure', 'cannot explain' or 'none'.

507 users reached, 67.5% chose a first step

Four findings summarise reach, decisions, differences by family background and remaining needs. The following slides present the evidence for each.



Reach

507

AI Mentor users

Ages 15–19, all 47 prefectures.
Includes 73 from mother-led households, 158 from lower-resource households and 10 outside school and work.

See pp. 4–5



A decision

67.5%

Chose a first step (342/507)

Immediately after consultation, 342 chose an action. Separate questions recorded clarification or a decision for 314 and selection or adaptation of suggestions for 243.

See p. 11



Conditional comparison

80% vs 81%

First-step selection among users who gave concrete post-use descriptions

Among those with concrete post-use descriptions, 80% (59/74) in lower-resource households and 81% (186/230) in other households chose a first step.

See p. 17



Post-use descriptions

53% vs 25%

Non-concrete post-use description

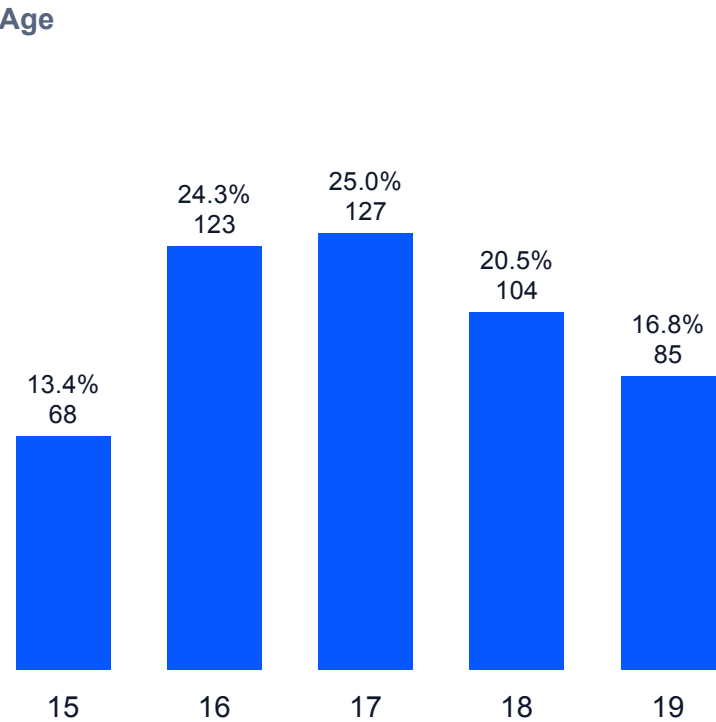
53% (84/158) in the lower-resource group did not describe their consultation concretely afterwards, versus 25% (75/305) in the other group. Reasons are unconfirmed.

See p. 26

Among users with concrete post-consultation descriptions, action-selection rates were 80% and 81%. This does not establish equal effects. How users proceed through and reflect on consultation, and connect with support, needs further study.

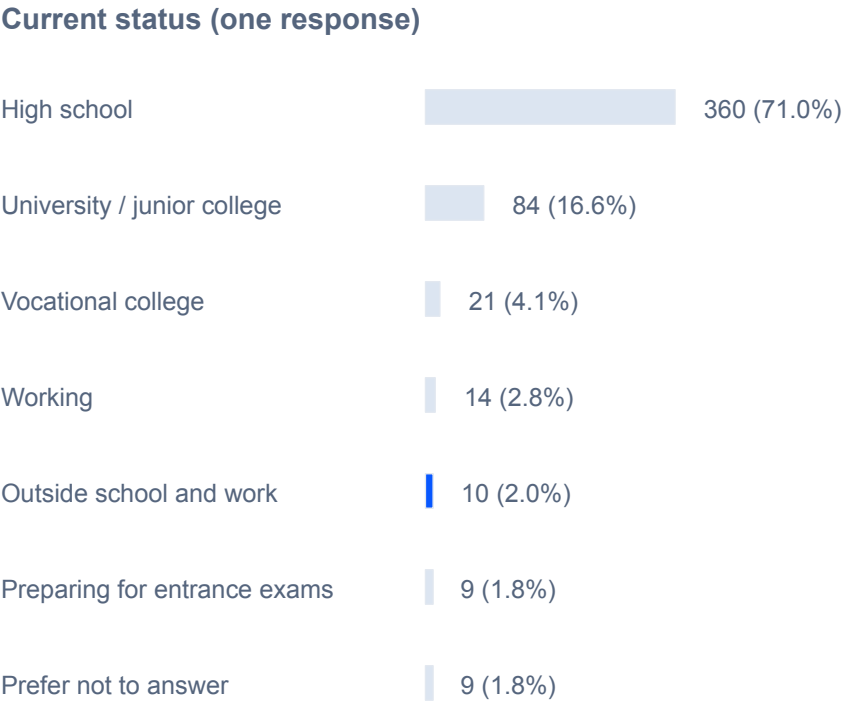
AI Mentor users aged 15–19 across all 47 prefectures

Users represented every age from 15 to 19 and all 47 prefectures. The group was uneven by student status and gender: 71.0% were high-school students and 73.4% were female.



507 users aged 15–19

Female: 372 (73.4%). Male: 135 (26.6%).

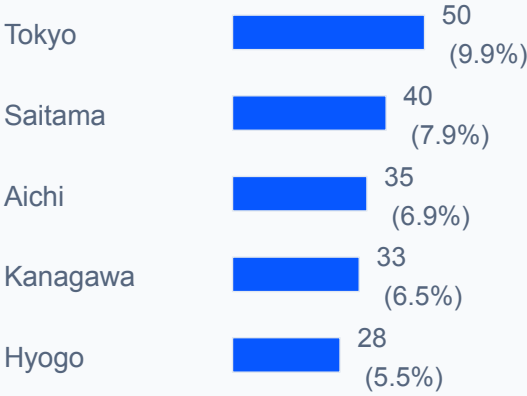


No junior-high students or other statuses.

Prefectures of residence

47

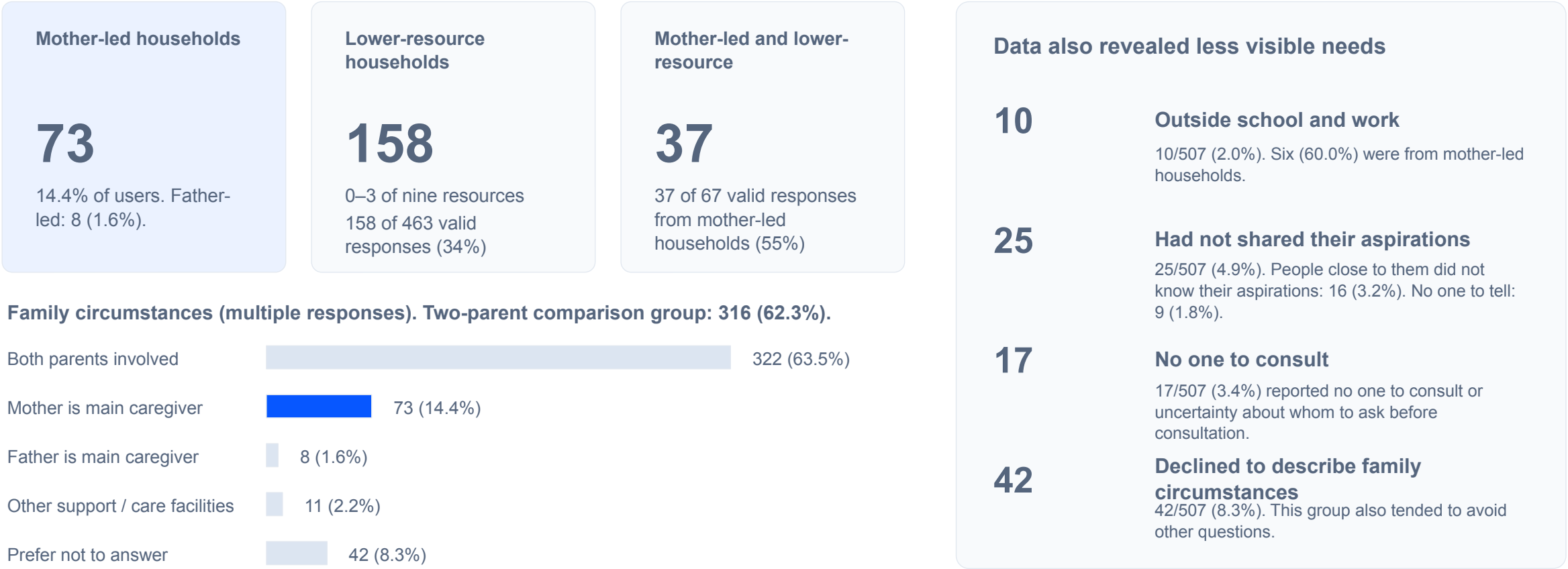
Users in all prefectures



321 (63.3%) in the other 42 prefectures

The same consultation reached underserved households

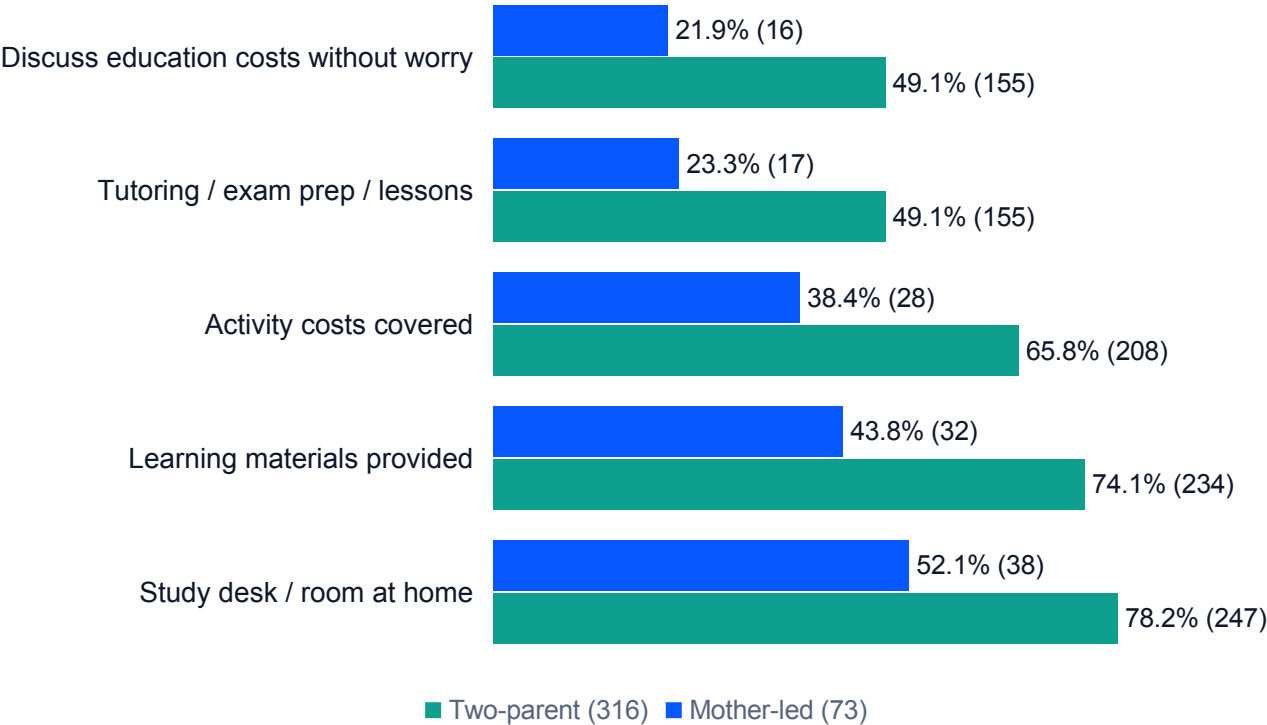
The project focuses on young people from single-parent households. All 507 users, from varied family circumstances, provided feedback after using the service.



Resources and topics among mother-led participants

Pre-consultation responses describe resources and selected topics by household background. They do not measure ability or experience in expressing concerns.

Reported access to everyday resources



Mother-led: 73. Two-parent: 316.

22%

Could discuss education costs without worry (16/73)

49% (155/316) in two-parent households. Lower-resource households accounted for 55% (37/67) of mother-led and 25% (75/306) of two-parent households.

1.4%

Mentioned money in their concern (1/73)

Money worries before consultation were similar: 14% (10/73) in mother-led and 12% (37/316) in two-parent households. Yet only one mother-led user articulated money as the concern.

20.5%

Chose anxiety / confidence as the topic (15/73)

12.3% (39/316) in two-parent households. This compares topics selected before consultation.

AI Mentor turns two chosen perspectives into a plan

This example recreates actual consultation output. AI presents eight perspectives around the user's goal. The user chooses two priorities, and AI develops a plan in three phases before the entrance exam.

1

Selected

Gap to the passing score

2

Weak subjects

3

Using mock exams

4

Past exam practice

The central goal

Keep studying until next spring to improve from a D rating and earn the scores needed for University X

5

Selected

A daily routine

6

Daily rhythm

7

Friends to study with

8

Someone to consult

AI advice: Identify how many more points you need, then make closing that gap a daily habit. Focus on subject scores, beyond the overall D rating.

Three phases proposed by AI

1

Now to September: establish a baseline

Goal: Know which subjects need improvement and set a daily start time.

Try: Review your latest mock exam by subject. List scores and missed topics. Set one reliable weekday study session, such as 30 minutes after getting home.

Progress: Name 3–5 weak subjects or topics and start at the agreed time about five days a week.

2

October to December: close the score gap

Goal: Reduce weaknesses and solve more questions than before.

Try: Record scores after each mock exam or practice session. Retry missed questions and prioritise subjects with room to improve.

Progress: Solve more previously missed questions correctly and explain how your scores have changed.

3

New year to exam day: secure reliable points

Goal: Work within the time limit and reliably solve the questions you should get right.

Try: Practise under exam timing, review mistakes and keep your established routine.

Progress: Feel comfortable with timed practice and know which topics need final review.

Example based on actual output. The university name is fictional. The next page turns this plan into the first week and five minutes today.

AwakApp

7



The plan specifies the first week and five minutes today

The consultation continues with a first-week plan, easier alternatives when users struggle and named people they can ask for help.

	Today (5–10 minutes)	Open your latest mock exam. Write each subject's score on paper or your phone. Mark subjects where you could earn more points.
	Tomorrow (10–30 minutes)	Choose three wrong answers. Note whether each came from missing knowledge, forgetting, lack of time or misreading.
	This week's challenge	Start with 30 minutes at the same time on five days. Decide the first subject in advance.
	How to check progress	Count days you started at the agreed time, rather than total study hours. Keep at least three problems you learned to solve this week.
	What can wait this week	Avoid jumping into long sessions or adding many books. First decide what to improve and establish a daily starting routine.
	If that feels difficult	Reduce 30 minutes to 10. Start with ten English words or one maths problem, and reduce days with no study.
	People to ask for help	Show your latest mock exam to your class teacher, careers adviser or tutor. Ask which subjects to prioritise and how many points to improve.

Today's first step

'For today, five minutes writing down your mock-exam scores by subject is enough.'

AI Mentor's closing sentence turns a large goal into five minutes of action today.

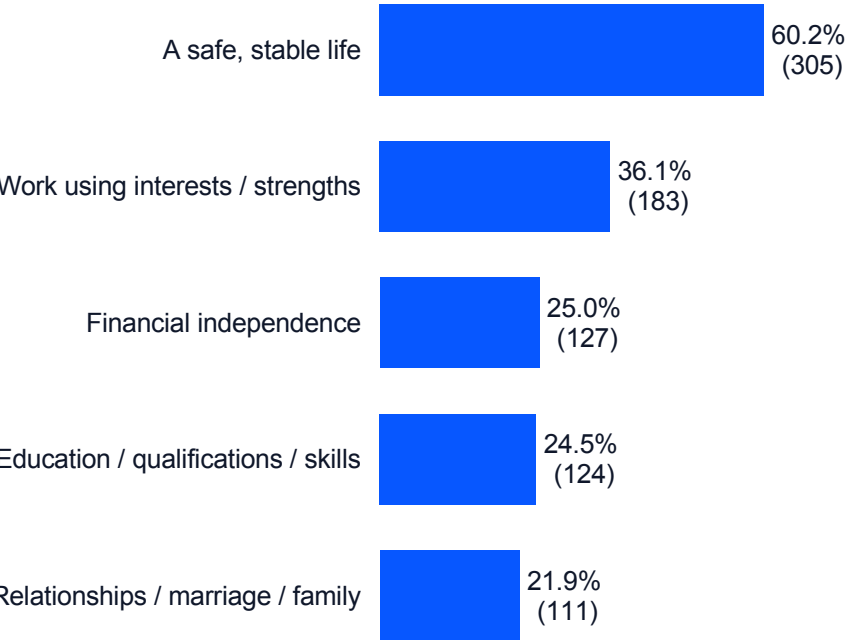
Connecting users to people

The plan names people users can ask for help. Only 3.7% (19/507) chose talking to someone as today's first step. Page 28 proposes how to strengthen this connection.

A stable life came first, and many were unsure what to ask

Before consultation, users most wanted a stable life. Education and aspirations led the consultation topics. The third most common response was uncertainty about what to discuss.

Aspirations (up to three responses)



507 users, up to three responses

Others' reactions to aspirations (one response)

50.3%

50.3% (255) had support from people close to them

- Active support: 30.0% (152)
- Support with worries or conditions: 20.3% (103)
- Aspirations undecided: 17.8% (90)
- Opposition, another path or indifference: 7.1% (36)
- Others unaware / no one to tell: 4.9% (25)

Desired AI topic (one response)

Education, exams, study, grades	18.9%	96
Dreams, goals, interests	16.0%	81
Not sure what to discuss	14.2%	72
Anxiety, confidence, motivation	12.0%	61
Family, friends, school relationships	8.7%	44
Future work and careers	6.7%	34
Tuition, scholarships, living costs	4.3%	22

Difficulty describing the consultation was the largest category

We classified each of the 507 written answers to 'What did you discuss with AI?' by its main theme after consultation.



Each written consultation response received one main-theme classification. Total: 507.

Two in three chose a first step immediately after use

Three separate questions recorded action selection, clarification or a decision, and selection or adaptation of suggestions. Responses overlap. These self-reports do not establish subsequent action or causal effects.

Chose a first step

67.5%

342 users chose a specific first action immediately after consultation.

Clarification / decision

61.9%

314 selected at least one response covering clearer goals or options, clarified concerns, or deciding what to do today.

Selected / adapted

47.9%

243 selected or adapted AI suggestions, or devised a different action themselves.

The same user's concern and first step

Studying for Eiken Grade 2: practise vocabulary
Male, 16, high school

University tuition: research scholarships
Female, 17, high school

Relationships: write down how I want to be
Male, 18, working

Knowing today's action increased from 10.8% to 16.4%

Before and immediately after consultation, users selected one of seven stages, from no settled goal to already taking action. This differs from the 67.5% measure on p. 11 and counts only the two most concrete stages.

Knew today's first action or had started it (507 users)

Before

After

10.8% → 16.4%

+5.6 percentage points

55 to 83 users

Changes within the same users (354 valid pairs)

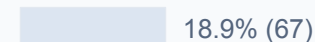
Moved to a more concrete stage



Stayed at the same stage



Moved back to an earlier stage



Seven stages: 1 No settled goal. 2 A goal I cannot explain. 3 Unsure of methods or options. 4 Priorities undecided. 5 Today's action undecided. 6 Today's first action decided. 7 First action already started.

Even users without a settled goal before consultation named actions afterwards, such as researching two universities or checking entrance-exam subjects.

First steps focused on study, information and daily routines

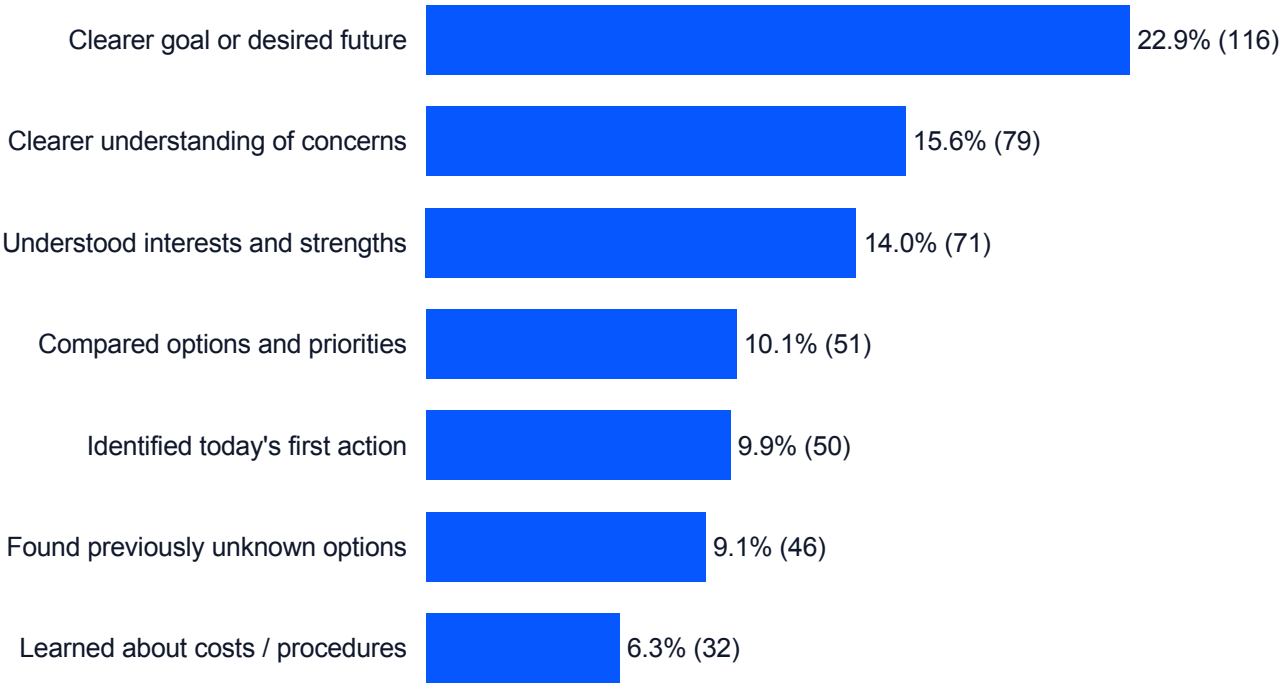
The top three first actions and examples from users who chose them. The full 507 also include other actions, 11 (2.2%), unsure, 34 (6.7%), and prefer not to answer, 67 (13.2%). One response per user.



A clearer goal was the most common new insight

Users selected up to two things they learned or clarified through consultation. 61.9% selected at least one of the seven positive outcomes.

What users learned or clarified (up to two)



507 users, up to two responses

Clarification / decision

61.9%

314 selected at least one of the seven items.

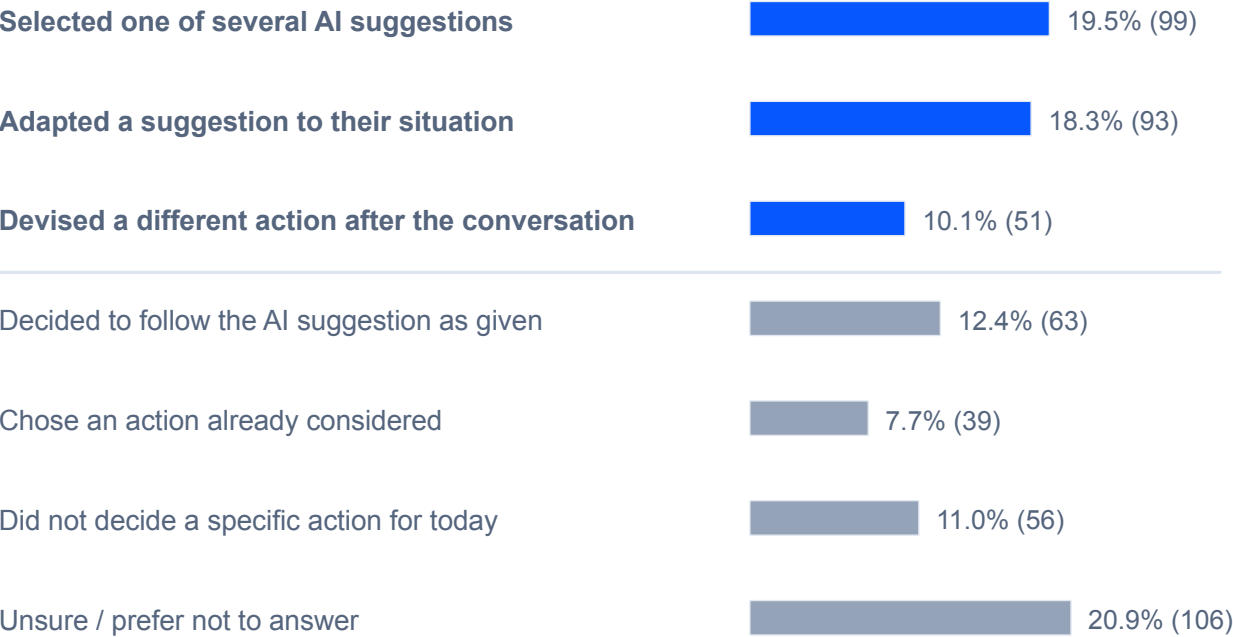
Users without improvement

11.6% (59): no particular change
1.2% (6): more uncertainty or confusion

Nearly half made their own choice about AI suggestions

Users chose how they decided on today's action. Selecting among suggestions, adapting one or devising a different action counts as making their own choice.

How today's action was chosen (one response)



Selected / adapted

47.9%

243 selected one of the three blue items.

A question for future evaluation

Future work should test how choosing an action relates to follow-through and persistence. This pilot recorded how participants decided immediately after consultation.

Outcomes differed by household resources across 463 users

We assessed resources using nine daily-life items in the pre-consultation questions. We split 463 valid respondents by how many items applied and compared the three outcomes.

Reported resources (507 users)

Daily life

Family meal out at least monthly	Domestic travel at least yearly	Overseas travel in the last three years	Family car
51.7% 262	30.6% 155	8.9% 45	66.7% 338

Learning environment

Tutoring / exam prep / lessons	Learning materials provided	Activity costs covered	Study desk / room
39.3% 199	60.7% 308	54.2% 275	66.9% 339

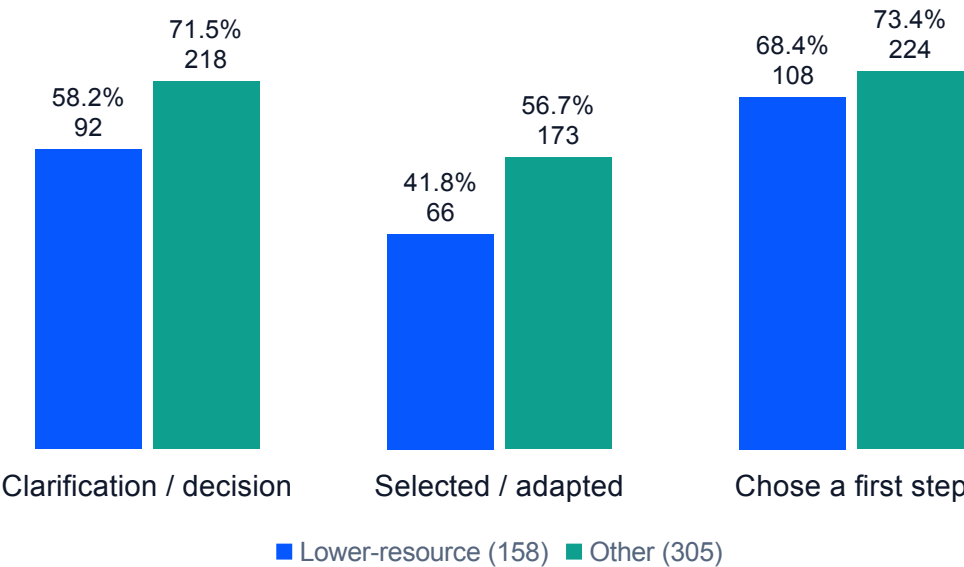
Discussing education

Can discuss education costs without worry
39.4% 200

Classification using pre-consultation responses

1. Select items Select applicable daily-life resources	2. Count items 0–9 for each user	3. Split groups 0–3: 158 users 4–9: 305 users	4. Compare 463 Exclude 44 unsure / declined
--	--	--	---

Three outcomes across 463 users

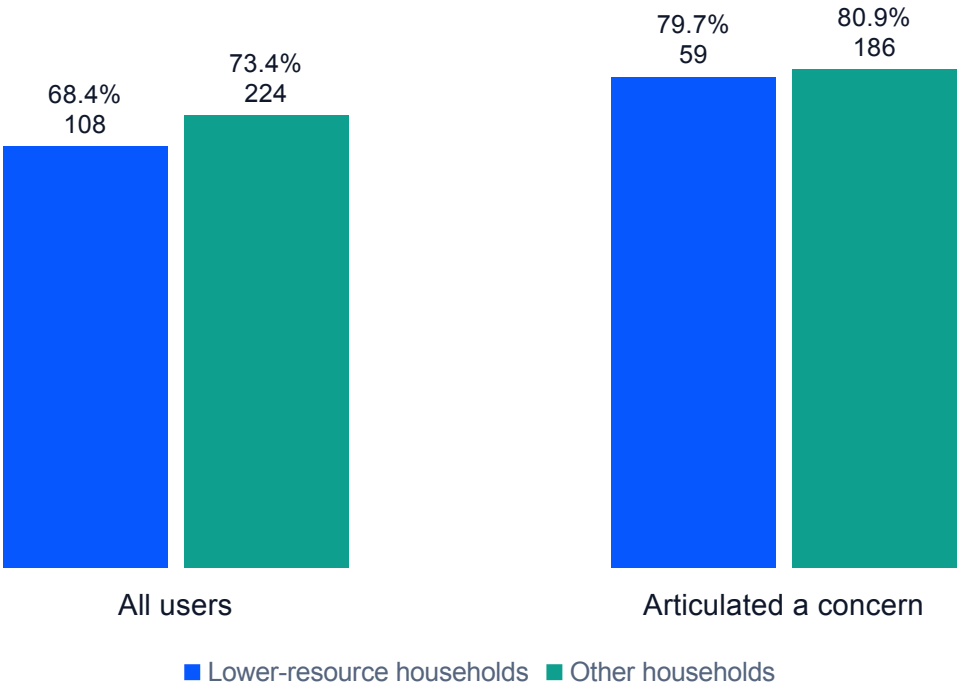


Counts, lower-resource / other: clarification or decision 92/218, selection or adaptation 66/173, first step 108/224. The largest gap was selection or adaptation: 56.7% minus 41.8% = 14.9 points. The next page groups participants by post-use descriptions.

Action selection was 80% and 81% among concrete descriptions

This comparison selects participants by their post-consultation descriptions. Similar percentages do not establish equal effects of AI or elimination of household disparities.

Chose a first step



All: 158 / 305. Articulated concern: 74 / 230.

Users who gave a concrete post-use description

80% vs 81%

Left: lower-resource, 80% (59/74). Right: other, 81% (186/230).
Clarification / decision: lower-resource, 73% (54/74), versus other, 81% (187/230).

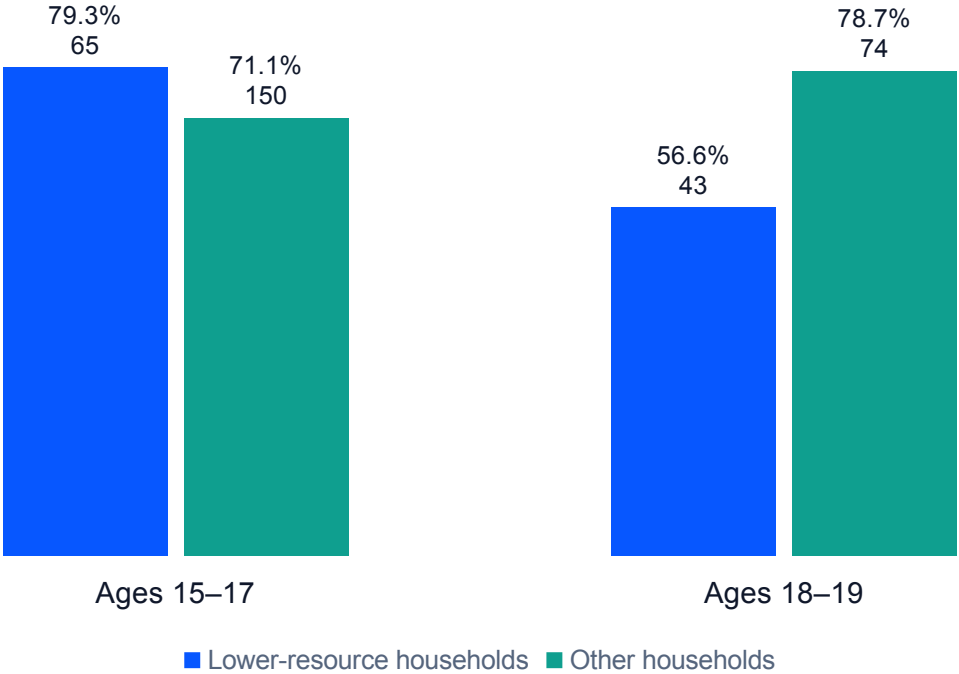
Mother-led households: idea gap narrows, action-choice gap remains

Among 37 mother-led users who gave concrete post-use descriptions, 76% (28) reported clarification or a decision, versus 80% (176/220) in two-parent households. The overall 53% (39/73) versus 69% (218/316) gap narrowed to four points. First-step selection remained 70% (26) versus 81% (179/220).

Household comparisons differed by age group

The lower-resource group's action-selection rate was higher at ages 15–17 and lower at ages 18–19. These descriptive comparisons do not establish effects of early intervention.

Chose a first step



Ages 15–17: 82 / 211. Ages 18–19: 76 / 94.

Ages 15–17, lower-resource (82 users)

79%

65/82, versus 71% (150/211) in other households. Among high-school students: lower-resource 80% (74/93), other 73% (175/239). These are descriptive subgroup comparisons.

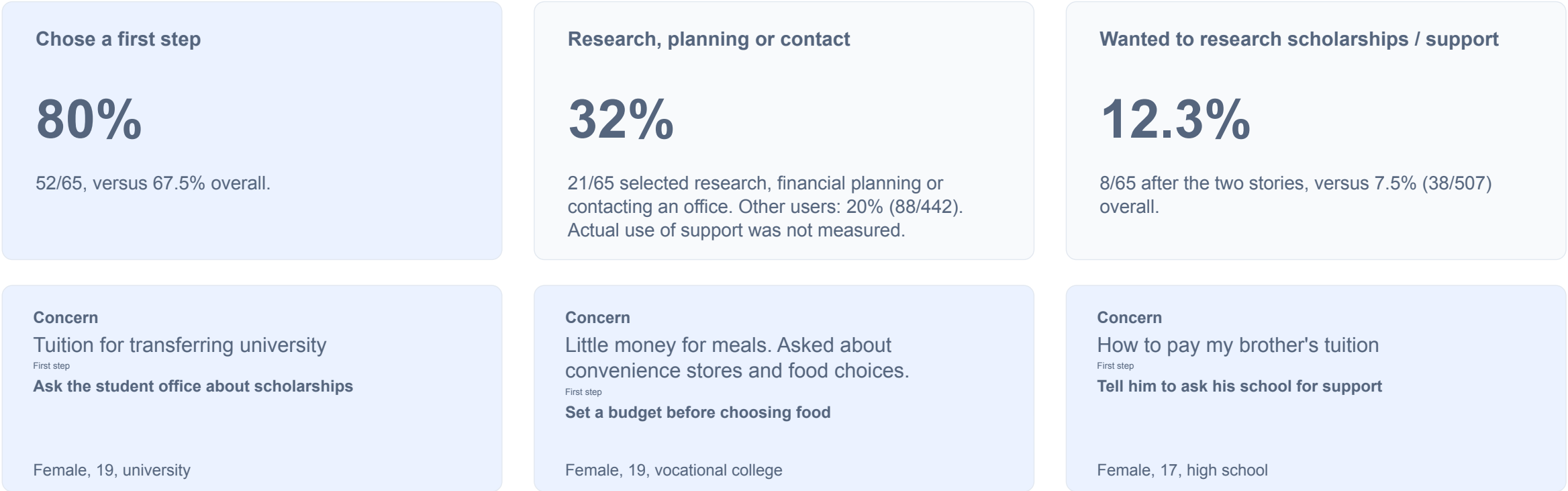
Ages 18–19, lower-resource (76 users)

57%

43/76, versus 79% (74/94) in other households. The reasons for this difference require further investigation. Proposed support is outlined on p. 28.

52 of 65 participants with money worries chose an action

Results for the 65 who reported money worries before consultation. This is separate from the 22 who chose money as their topic on p. 9. Their first-step selection rate exceeded the overall rate.



25 of the 65 who selected money worries before consultation selected it again afterwards (38.5%). This informs consideration of guidance to people and support services (p. 23).

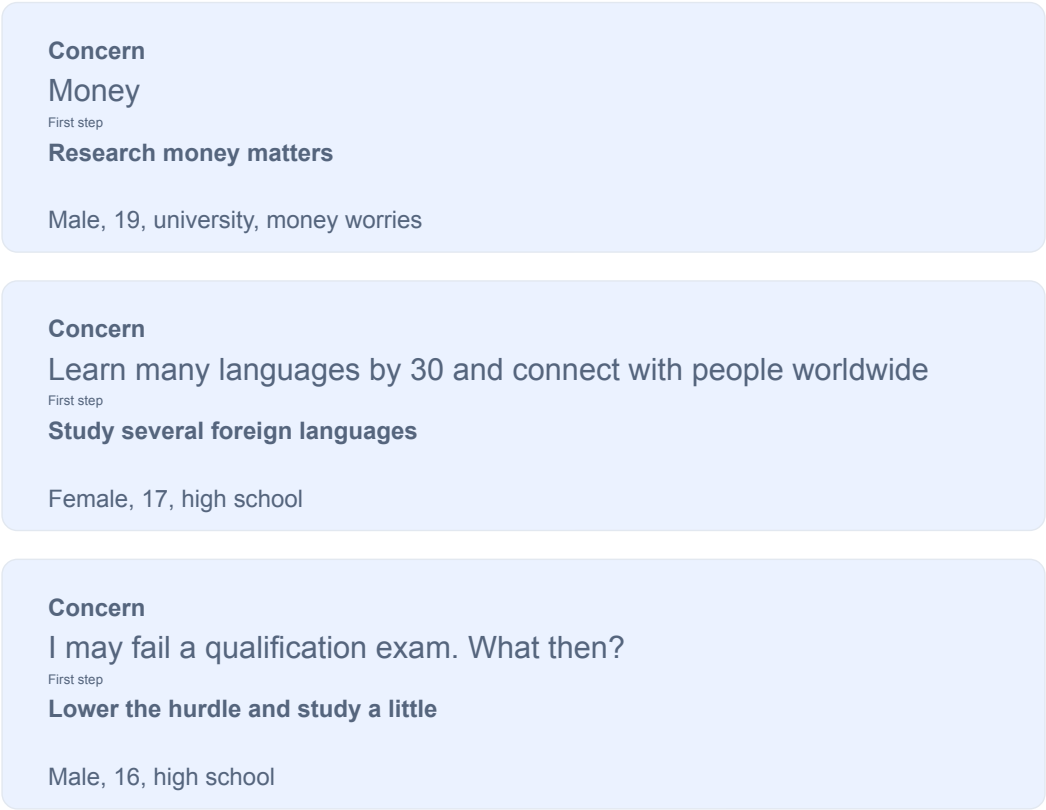
17 of 73 mother-led participants chose to research information

Among participants naming their mother as main guardian, 18 reported missing information before consultation and 17 chose research afterwards. These are separate questions, not proof that information needs were resolved.



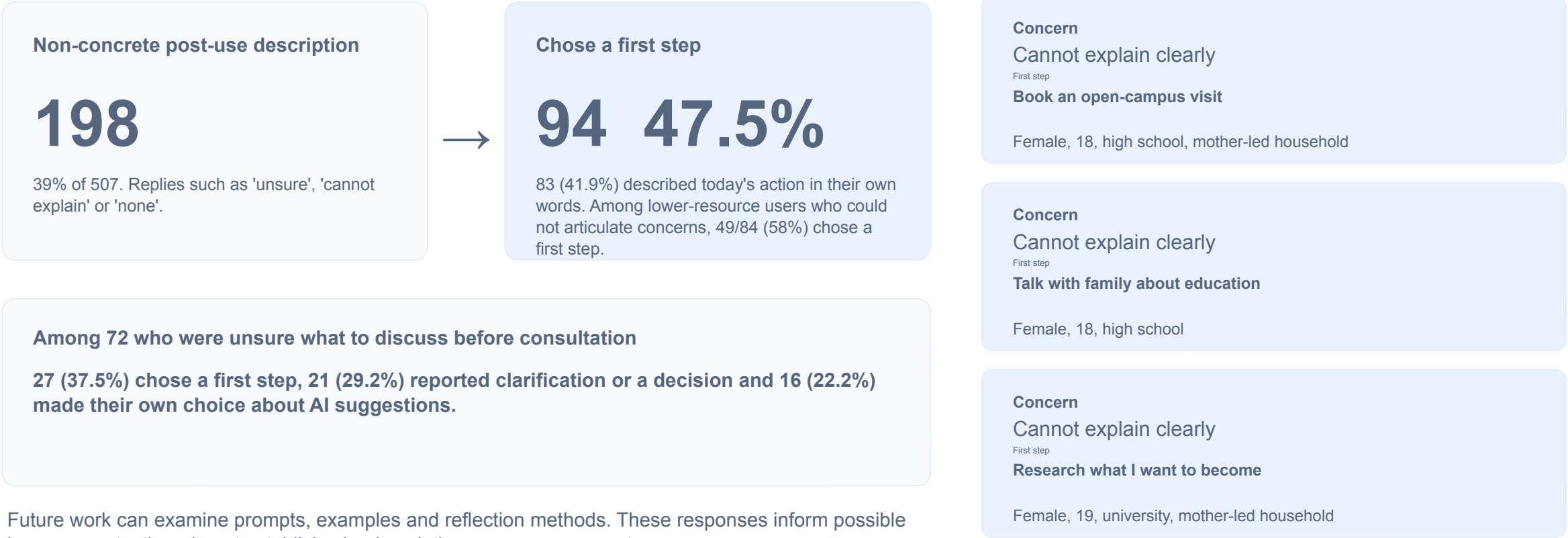
After consultation, mother-led users: clarification / decision 53% (39/73), first step 62% (45/73), no remaining problem 13.7% (10/73). Two-parent, no problem: 10.1% (32/316).

Overall rates were below the full group, but the gap narrowed among the 37 who gave concrete post-use descriptions (p. 17).



94 of 198 with non-concrete descriptions also chose an action

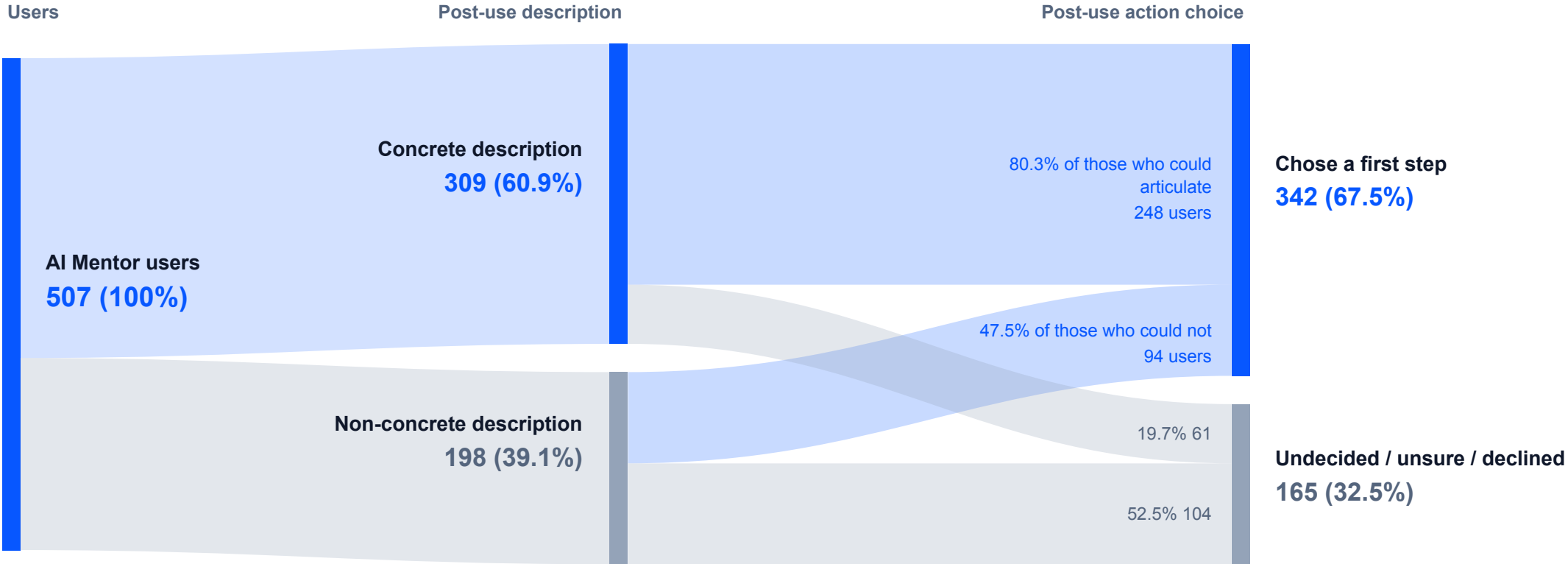
Nearly half of participants without concrete post-consultation descriptions chose an action. These responses alone do not establish their ability to describe concerns beforehand or why their descriptions were non-concrete.



Future work can examine prompts, examples and reflection methods. These responses inform possible improvements; they do not establish why descriptions were non-concrete.

Action selection and post-consultation descriptions

The diagram relates post-consultation descriptions to action selection. Band widths show counts. It does not establish a sequence of stages or a causal relationship.

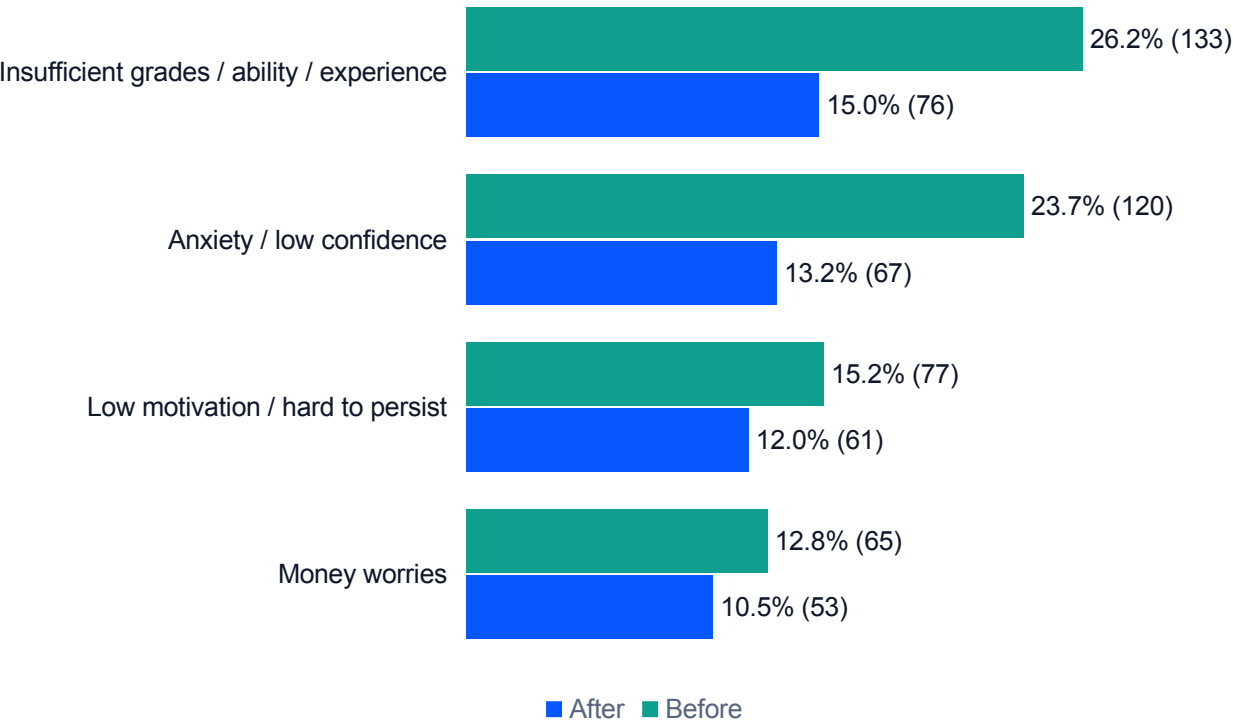


80.3% (248/309) with concrete descriptions and 47.5% (94/198) without them chose an action. Description and action selection are associated; causes are unconfirmed.

Fewer selected anxiety or ability concerns after consultation

All 507 users chose up to two barriers to their aspirations from the same options before and immediately after consultation.

Reported barriers



507 users, up to two responses

Points are percentage-point differences. For example, 26.2% to 15.0% is a fall of 11.2 points.

–11.2 / –10.5 percentage points

Lower selection rates

Grades, ability or experience: 26.2% to 15.0% (133 to 76). Anxiety or low confidence: 23.7% to 13.2% (120 to 67). Users selected up to two items. This does not measure severity or establish a causal effect.

–2.4 percentage points

Small change in money-worry selection

12.8% to 10.5% (65 to 53). Among 22 selecting money as their topic, 77.3% (17) reported clarification or a decision and 86.4% (19) chose an action. This does not establish relief of worry or use of support services.

7.3% → 10.3%

More reported no remaining problem

7.3% (37) to 10.3% (52). However, uncertainty about information accuracy rose from 14.8% to 19.9%, informing the improvements on p. 28.

37.1% responded positively to the global scholarship story

After AI consultation, we introduced peers pursuing global opportunities despite limited resources. The story covered income differences between Japan, India and the Philippines, IIT scholarships for low-income families, and students continuing to the US, Europe and elsewhere.

Positive reaction after reading

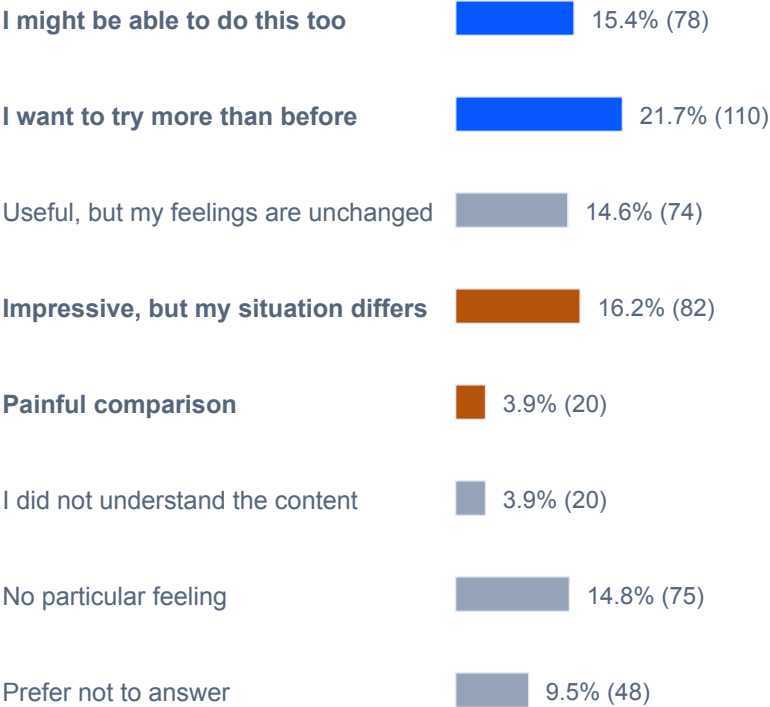
37.1%

188/507: 'I might be able to do this too', 15.4% (78), and 'I want to try more', 21.7% (110).

Story summary from the questionnaire

The story cited average annual household income of about JPY 900,000 in the Philippines and JPY 5.24 million in Japan, and IIT scholarships for families earning roughly JPY 800,000 or less. It described peers continuing to universities or companies abroad: 'People around the world have kept pursuing their paths despite their family's financial circumstances.'

Reaction after reading (one response, 507)



About one in ten mother-led users felt pain

Mother-led (73) Two-parent (316)

Positive: could do it + want to try
34.2% **41.5%**
25/73 **131/316**

Different situation
15.1% **18.4%**
11/73 **58/316**

Painful comparison
9.6% 7/73 **2.8% 9/316**

Income comparisons and institutional figures also caused painful comparisons for some users facing family difficulties. Reactions differed from the IITH student's message on the next page.

52.3% responded positively to the IITH student's message

The second story came from an Indian Institute of Technology Hyderabad student. Neither parent attended university. Without money for textbooks, the student used libraries and free materials, researched scholarships and entered university, recounting the experience in their own words.

Positive reaction after reading

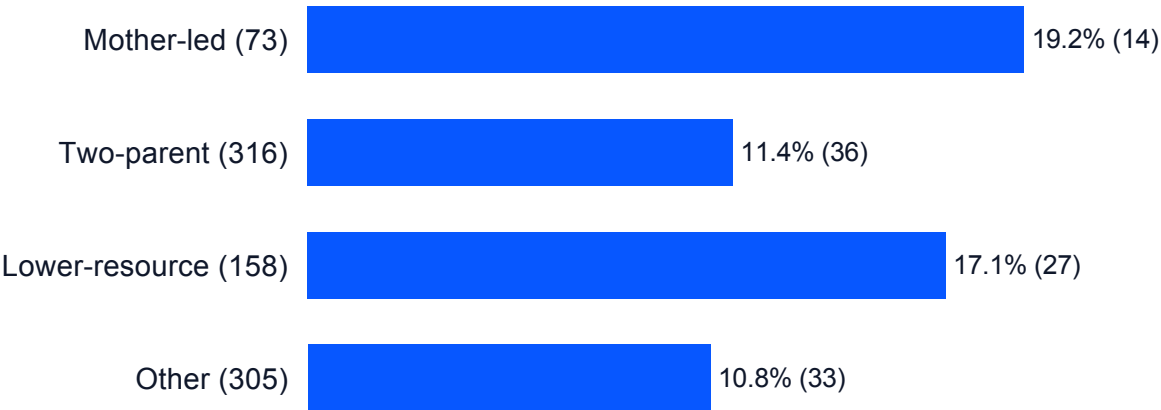
52.3%

265/507: encouraged, 30.0% (152), reassured by someone in similar circumstances, 13.0% (66), interested in overseas opportunities, 9.3% (47). About 15 points above the previous story's 37.1%.

'I had no special talent. What made a difference was doing my own research and continuing a small step each day. We cannot choose the family we are born into. We can choose what to do tomorrow.'

Excerpt from the IITH student's message

Reassured by learning of someone in similar circumstances



Positive reactions include two options on the previous page and three here.

Mother-led users felt less encouraged, but more reassured

Encouraged: mother-led 26% (19/73), two-parent 35% (112/316). Reassured: 19.2% versus 11.4%, about 1.7 times. Increased anxiety: mother-led 9.6% (7), two-parent 4.1% (13). After both stories, 46.5% (236) reported commitment, a new action or a link to a larger goal. 7.5% (38) wanted to research scholarships or support.

507 users revealed four gaps to address next

These self-reports identify four questions for further investigation. Their causes and the effects of proposed improvements require additional evidence.



25/65 (38.5%) who selected money worries beforehand selected it again afterwards. Further work should examine barriers to action and guidance to people and services.

Three findings from the AI consultation pilot

A summary of participants, household comparisons and questions for further work. The pilot did not compare AI with human support.



Reach

507 users

Ages 15–19 across all 47 prefectures

The same consultation experience reached all 47 prefectures, including 73 mother-led users, 158 lower-resource users and 10 outside school and work.



Conditional comparison

80% vs 81%

First step among those with concrete post-use descriptions
Lower-resource 59/74, other 186/230

The comparison selects users with concrete post-use descriptions. Equal effects are unconfirmed. 79% (65/82) of lower-resource users aged 15–17 and 80% (52/65) with money worries chose an action. 21 of the latter chose research, planning or contact.



Visible needs

4 gaps

Priorities for the next design

Responses from 507 users reveal patterns by household background. Descriptions of consultations, available contacts and money worries can inform future support.

Water Dragon Foundation funding enabled this consultation experience and outcome assessment, helping young people clarify concerns and consider a first step.

People and support services at entry and after consultation

Entry means starting consultation; exit means acting afterwards. These four proposed approaches draw on participant responses. They are future options, not implemented functions with demonstrated effects.

01 Dialogue at entry

Use prompts and examples that let users begin with 'I don't know'. Help identify the consultation topic together.

Measure: non-concrete descriptions after consultation. Current rates: lower-resource 53% (84/158), other 25% (75/305).

02 Discuss money and support early

Ask early about tuition, living costs and support. Give specific routes to grants or student services, and explain information reliability.

Measure: money worries remaining after consultation. Current: 38.5% (25/65).

03 A person at the next step

After choosing a first step, ask 'Who will you tell?' Name a teacher, support organisation or consultation office.

Measure: choosing to talk to someone. Mother-led users, current: 0% (0/73).

04 Transition support for ages 18–19

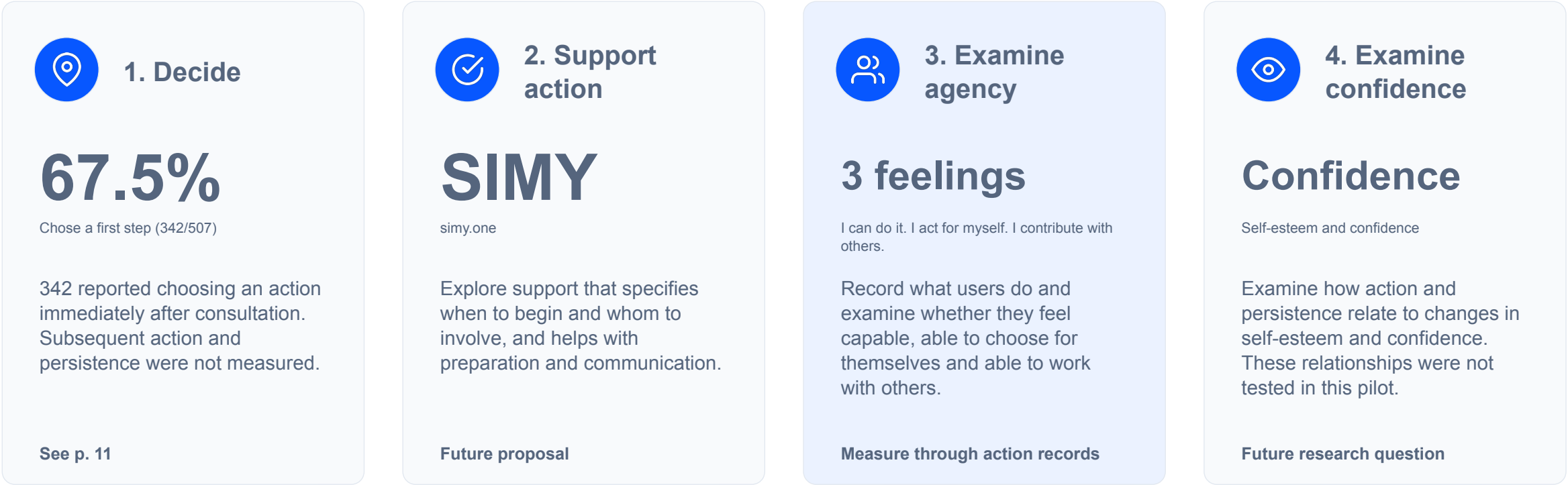
Address tuition, independent living, work and transfers. Answer specific questions with specific information before broadening to eight perspectives.

Measure: first-step selection, lower-resource users aged 18–19. Current: 57% (43/76).

Revise the stories to emphasise struggles and small steps. Painful comparison with the global scholarship story: mother-led 9.6% (7/73), two-parent 2.8% (9/316). The IITH story reassured 19% (14) of mother-led users. Offer 2–3 AI suggestions and ask how users would adapt them to their situation.

Exploring support for carrying out chosen steps through SIMY

This pilot recorded choices immediately after consultation. We will draw on AI Mentor findings when considering how SIMY could support follow-through in youth services. The following are proposed approaches.



The pilot recorded action selection. Future evaluation should examine follow-through, persistence and confidence. Proposed measures include completed steps, choosing to consult someone and self-reported self-esteem.



We cannot choose the family we are born into. We can choose what to do tomorrow.

With Water Dragon Foundation funding, 507 young people used AI consultation. 342 chose an action afterwards. Among those with concrete post-use descriptions, rates were 80% and 81% across household groups. Equal effects and subsequent action were not established. These findings will inform proposed SIMY support for consultation, reflection and follow-through.

507 users

All 47 prefectures

67.5%

Chose a first step (342/507)

80% vs 81%

First step among users with concrete post-use descriptions

Lower-resource versus other households